ITALY · PUGLIA

# Puglia

4 Day Southern Italy Road Journey

| DESTINATION | DURATION | IDEAL FOR |
| --- | --- | --- |
| Italy, Puglia | 4 days | 2–6 people |

YOUR JOURNEY

# Expedition Route

Italy · Puglia · 4 days

**DAY 1**
Bari · Polignano a Mare

**DAY 2**
Polignano · Ostuni · Brindisi · Lecce

**DAY 3**
Lecce · Valle d'Itria · Alberobello

**DAY 4**
Alberobello · Matera

## JOURNEY HIGHLIGHTS

- Polignano a Mare: the town built on a cliff above the Adriatic
- Alberobello's trulli: the only town of its kind in the world
- Lecce baroque — more ornate than Rome, less visited than anywhere
- Ostuni, the White City — a whitewashed labyrinth on a limestone hill
- Matera: the ancient cave city across the border in Basilicata
- The Valle d'Itria: trulli, vineyards and dry-stone walls

DAY 1

# Bari & Polignano a Mare

Arrive in Bari and walk the old city before the heat of the day. Bari Vecchia is a labyrinth of limestone alleys and women making orecchiette in doorways — the most honest two square kilometres in southern Italy. Drive south to Polignano a Mare in the afternoon: the village built on a cliff above sea caves, with the Adriatic directly below the main square.

- Bari Vecchia — the medieval walled city with its street pasta makers
- Basilica di San Nicola — Romanesque Puglian architecture at its most severe
- Polignano a Mare — the clifftop town above the Adriatic sea caves
- Lama Monachile cove — the pebble beach below the old town bridge

INSIDER TIP

In Bari Vecchia, the pasta-making women work from their doorsteps in the morning — this is a daily ritual, not a performance, and they sell directly. Polignano a Mare is best in the evening when the day-trippers have gone; the clifftop main square is genuinely dramatic with the sea far below.

DAY 2

# Ostuni, Brindisi & Lecce

Drive south through the olive-grove flatlands to Ostuni — the White City on its limestone hill, visible for miles before you arrive. Walk the old town before lunch. Continue to Brindisi: the end of the Appian Way, the column that marked the final mile of Rome. Arrive in Lecce in the late afternoon: the baroque city that makes even Italian baroque look restrained.

- Ostuni — the whitewashed hilltop city at the edge of the Murge plateau
- Brindisi Column — the terminal marker of the Appian Way from Rome
- Lecce baroque — the soft local limestone that made extreme ornamentation possible
- Piazza del Duomo, Lecce — one of the most theatrical squares in southern Italy

INSIDER TIP

Ostuni's old town is best walked without a map — get lost in the whitewashed alleys above the main square. Lecce's soft pietra leccese limestone allows extreme decorative carving that harder stones cannot achieve; this is why the baroque here is more intricate than Rome's. The Lecce Archaeological Museum is free and excellent.

DAY 3

# Valle d'Itria — Alberobello & the Trulli Country

Drive north into the Valle d'Itria. Alberobello is the reason to come here: the only town in the world built entirely of trulli — the conical limestone drystone houses with whitewashed walls. UNESCO designation has made it popular but not ruined it. Afternoon in the valley: Locorotondo, Cisternino, Martina Franca. The valleys here are genuinely beautiful at dusk.

- Alberobello trulli — 1,500 conical limestone structures, a UNESCO World Heritage Site
- Locorotondo — a circular hilltop town with a perfect historic centre
- Cisternino — one of the 'most beautiful villages in Italy', genuinely unspoiled
- Valle d'Itria — the valley of trulli, vineyards and cherry orchards

INSIDER TIP

Alberobello is most photogenic in the early morning or late afternoon — midday light is flat. The Trullo Sovrano is the only two-storey trullo in existence and worth the small entry fee. Locorotondo has better restaurants than Alberobello and is genuinely calmer; consider basing the evening there.

DAY 4

# Matera — the Ancient Cave City

Cross the regional border into Basilicata. Matera is one of the oldest continuously inhabited cities in the world — a Sassi of cave dwellings carved into the ravine walls, occupied since the Palaeolithic, which the Italian government emptied in the 1950s and the city has slowly been reoccupying since. It is unlike anywhere else. Return to Bari for departure.

- Matera Sassi — cave dwellings inhabited for over 9,000 years, a UNESCO World Heritage Site
- Sasso Caveoso — the older of the two Sassi districts, with rupestrian churches
- Murgia Plateau viewpoint — for the panorama over the ravine and cave city
- Madonna de Idris — the rock-hewn church carved into the Matera cliff face

INSIDER TIP

Navigate the Sassi by descending from Piazza Vittorio Veneto and following route markers through Sasso Barisano first. The rupestrian churches are carved into rock — many require a torch or phone light. The Murgia Plateau viewpoint is reached by a 20-minute drive across the ravine and is the only angle from which the full scale of the cave city is comprehensible.

HIDDENATLAS

# Ready to make this trip yours?

This guide gives you the structure and route.
Our planners can build the personalised version around your dates, travel style and pace.

- Refined route planning and pacing
- Carefully selected areas to stay
- Logistics guidance for a smooth journey
- Insider tips from on-the-ground research

**START PLANNING YOUR TRIP**
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